GUIDED MEDITATION ON SELF-FORGIVENESS [TRANSCRIPT]

TARA BRACH: As you settle in, closing your eyes, just sense if there's any subtle ways of shifting how you're sitting. So that you're really-- in that you're sitting alert and really at ease. Feel comfortable. You might take some moments to relax any obvious areas of tension in your body, to see what wants to let go.

You might feel the breath at the heart, as if could flow in and out of the heart. You sense the mood this moment in your heart.

And as you're listening inward, to listen to your intention-- to, in some way, open your heart, free your heart as we practice together.

Scanning your life, bringing to mind some aspect of yourself, some behavior-- past or could be current-- that has felt unforgivable. And encouragement is not to pick something that feels deeply traumatizing in some way. It's a sense for yourself. The level of charge that feels workable.

So where have you been pushing yourself out of your own heart? Perhaps, it's because you feel like you are too judgmental and controlling. Or there may be particular ways you've hurt other people that matter to you. Maybe it's hard to forgive yourself for harming your own life, perhaps with addictive behavior of some sort.

As you're sensing what is unforgivable, you might just really let yourself lean in and sense, well, what's so long or bad about this behavior, or emotion, or way of thinking? In other words, let yourself feel the aversion that's there. What's the worst part about this?

Now, let your attention explore more deeply. What is driving this part of you that's acting in an unacceptable way? You can even go right to where you-- some part of the mental movie of where you have caused harm. Just sense the behavior. And sense what's driving it.

If you're addicted to food, or nicotine, or alcohol maybe, what needs are you trying to satisfy? What fears are you trying to soothe? What's going on inside you when you're in some way acting out in a way that you then condemn?

If you wounded another person, were you acting from hurt? From insecurity? Out of the need to feel in control and safe?

See if you can witness yourself in your vulnerability through the eyes of the most understanding and loving friend, or relative, or deity, or the most awake part of your own being. So you're really beginning to see how you've got a leg in a trap, in some way, when you're acting in the ways that you condemn.

As you become aware of the underlying wants and fears, allow yourself to feel them directly in your body, and your heart, your mind. Even though you dislike the behaviors, try to hold the underlying vulnerability with compassion. Wise and caring witness, and yet very engaged.

You might experiment with placing your hand on your heart to really be in relationship with the part of you that's having a hard time. That's vulnerable. You might sense what message, what communication of self-forgiveness most would be healing.

There's classic phrases of self-compassion, such as, "I see I've caused myself suffering, and I forgive myself now." You might simply offer yourself the words "forgiven, forgiven." And there

may be other simple words, like, "It's OK. I care about the suffering." Or maybe it's a wordless stream of energy that's just tender.

See if you can meet whatever is arising right now-- whether it's fear, or judgment, or shame, or grief, or numbness-- with the message of forgiveness. Or even resistance. Forgiven, forgiven.

If it's helpful, you might call on the presence of someone you consider to be really loving and understanding. And feel their compassion falling into you, supporting you-- their mercy, their kindness.

If you get stuck, you can remind yourself, "It's my intention to forgive myself when I'm able."

It can be helpful to scan and notice if there's any judgment that's been creeping in about how you're doing with the self-forgiveness practice. You can add "forgiven, forgiven" to that too.

So more and more, there's that sense of the space that's including whatever's here with forgiveness. More and more, you're resting in a truth or a wholeness of being, that's inherently tender and kind.

These next few minutes, you can stay in silence inwardly. Or if you'd like to use your journal to just note whatever insights, or openings, or challenges emerge for you as you intend to hold your being with forgiveness.